



Above The Bazaar-e Bozorg is a 400-year-old market selling an astonishing array of goods, including a vast range of spices

Left It is said that nearly half a million tiles make up the exquisite mosaic patterning and calligraphy decorating the Masjid-e Emam, or Imam Mosque



Above The thick, dark sauce of *khoresh-e fesenjan* surprises the taste buds with its unique sweet-bitter flavor from pomegranates and walnuts

What Else to Eat

Khoresh-e fesenjan is a great example of a *khoresh* or sauce-based dish, but there are many others, such as **khoresh-e bademjan** (eggplant with chicken, lamb, or duck), **khoresh-e ghormeh sabzi** (lamb cooked in a sauce of fresh green herbs), and **khoresh torsh** (lamb with dried fruit). Along with plenty of fresh herbs and spices such as cinnamon and nutmeg, another popular ingredient you may encounter in these dishes is whole dried lime, which imparts a wonderful flavor. The accompaniment to *khoresh* is a mountain of perfectly cooked rice. Iranians generally eat their main meal in the middle of the day, so look for *khoresh* then, rather than in the evening.

The Best Places to Eat Khoresh-e Fesenjan

Restoran-e Shahrzad moderate

In the center of Isfahan and only a short walk from the Meydan-e Emam, Restoran-e Shahrzad serves some of the finest Persian cuisine in Isfahan – including a delicious *khoresh-e fesenjan*. There is a good range of dishes on the menu, from golden *tachin* (see p179) and other rice dishes to fish and sizzling kebabs. Portions are generous, the staff polite and efficient, and the interior decor suitably lavish, complete with wood paneling, colorful stained glass windows, and paintings in the style of Persian miniatures. Prices are slightly higher than average for Isfahan, but still very reasonable. As with most restaurants, the *fesenjan* here is made with chicken rather than duck – but it is nevertheless incredibly rich and fragrant, deep-colored and bursting with sweet and sour flavors. The buttery rice is, as always, a perfect partner to this heady stew. The long-established Shahrzad is understandably popular with locals as well as foreign visitors, and is both a great place to eat out in Isfahan and a wonderful introduction to the delicious Persian *fesenjan*.

Abbas Abad Street, Isfahan; open 11:30 AM–10:30 PM daily; +98 311 220 4490

Also in Isfahan

The **Khan Gostar** restaurant (+98 311 627 8989; *moderate*) in the Hotel Julfa is one of the best places to eat in town – perhaps as good as Shahrzad – and a good place to try a range of Persian dishes. Popular with Isfahanis, this restaurant is farther from downtown, but an obvious choice if you're spending time in Isfahan's historic Armenian quarter. By far the most atmospheric place to sip tea in town is in the **teahouse** (*inexpensive*) under the Si-o Se bridge – you may even find *abgusht*, a thick meat and potato stew that's a specialty of Tabriz in northwest Iran, rather than *khoresh*.

Also in Iran

Ferdosi Sonnati (+98 21 6671 4503; *inexpensive*) is a busy place at the southern end of Ferdosi Street in Tehran, which serves plenty of traditional Persian dishes including several types of *khoresh*.

Around the World

One of the best Persian restaurants in London is **Shandi's** (www.shandispersianrestaurant.co.uk; *moderate*). Smaller and less well-known than some others, this gem of a restaurant has excellent food, reasonable prices, and offers a genuinely warm welcome. The *khoresh-e fesenjan* is delicious.